nobles and the clergy, every one of them," announces a character in a thirteenth-century French satire. "Everything that is tasty and good goes to them."[4]

In January of 1251, the Pastoureaux entered Orleans, armed with "swords, axes, darts, daggers and long knives" ("They seemed to cherish the thoughts of war more than of Christ," Paris remarks), and swept through the city, attacking and killing clergymen, burning and raiding as they went. Similar mobs stormed churches in Tours and Bourges. Blanche immediately withdrew her support. "I believed that they, in their simplicity and sanctity, were about to win the whole earth," she declared. "But since they are deceivers, let them be excommunicated, seized, and destroyed." Royal officials began a manhunt. Within the year, the Pastoureaux had been cut to pieces in hand-to-hand fighting, arrested and hanged, or driven into the rivers to drown; the Master himself was killed by a militant Parisian butcher wielding an ax, who "struck him on the head and sent him brainless to hell."[5]



51.1 The Pastoureaux

France, vulnerable to English ambitions and wracked by internal chaos, soon lost its regent as well. In November of 1252, Blanche—well into her sixties—died after a short illness. Hearing of his mother's death, Louis shut himself in his chambers for two days, speaking to no one, and then finally made preparations to return to France.

He arrived back in Paris on September 7, 1254. For six years, he had been